the offer. Most decisions are clear cut, but borderline choices can prey on the mind.

Flower and Prior played pivotal roles in helping me reach the decision to reinstate KP. Neither deserved KP's subsequent criticism. We exchanged views in three- or four-day cycles, after mulling over the issues. Matty was opinionated, but team orientated. I trusted his views, having spent a lot of time on the field chatting as slip fielder to his wicketkeeper. He strongly supported Kevin's return.

Andy had more to juggle. He had built a close relationship with Straussy over the previous three years and had dealt with recurring tensions. Kevin was high maintenance, difficult to manage, but worth the extra effort because of his special talent. Loyalties were entrenched, and I knew I would have to sell his return to his teammates.

Above all, Andy is a principled man. His clashes with KP are a matter of public record, but he thought rationally, and suggested I could make the reunion work. I wasn't a particularly close friend of Kevin and can count on one hand the times I went for dinner with him in our eight years together, but I saw potential for progress.

We were polar opposites in terms of personality but had never clashed. As batsmen we suited each other down to the ground. Left hand, right hand. A sponge and a top gun. My fondness for going under the radar worked well, because KP fed off my calmness. Andy was right. We did make it work, in my eyes at least, for a while.

We both laughed nervously when Andy said: 'This will go one of two ways, but it is definitely going to be better than ending a bloke's career for good.' I was armed with a list of questions when I met KP in London to chat through things. It was awkward, initially, but he talked a good game, in stressing his eagerness to carry on playing for England.

He gave all the right answers. He knew he needed to clarify his commitment and playing for England built his brand. I prided myself that my teams worked their bollocks off, even on the shittiest of tours, and he had to buy into that. I never had a direct issue with Kevin, though I didn't like the way he attempted to manipulate Strauss. He's a man of fascinating, sometimes bizarre contrasts and, to be fair, did go to Andrew's house to apologize personally, for ruining his final Test.

That's the paradox. Someone summed him up as the bloke you would buy a drink for without hanging around for him to buy you one back. That's